Guitar Exercises - Section XII, Level 85

Pocket, Note Length, Muting, Attack Placement, and Drum/Bass Lock

Level 85 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. Section XII begins here. HARD STOP after Level 105.

The new objective is not harder subdivision. It is making the same subdivision feel different through note duration, muting, accent, register, and relationship to the rhythm section.

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	TOTAL	1440

Core rule: the grid stays stable while the feel changes.

Reference - One Grid, Several Grooves

Maintain continuous sixteenth-note hand motion: D U D U. P = pitched contact, x = muted contact, - = air stroke, ~ = sustain.

Name	1 e & a 2 e & a 3 e & a 4 e & a	Primary variable
Open eighths	P - P - P - P - P - P - P - P -	long duration
Clipped eighths	P - x - P - x - P - x - P - x -	left-hand release
Backbeat chop	P - - - x - P - P - - - x - P -	2/4 emphasis
Offbeat stab	- - P - - - P - - - P - - - P -	& attacks
Ghost grid	P x x x P x x x P x x x P x x x	muted subdivision
3+3+2	P - - P - - P - P - - P - - P -	accent grouping

Module A - Subdivision-to-Groove Conversion

Use one chord - Am7 - for every cell. Do not change harmony while learning the feel.

Pass	Instruction
1	Clap contacts; foot marks quarter notes.
2	Muted strings only; no pitched chord.
3	Am7 shell, all notes sustained.
4	Same attacks, but release every note at the printed cutoff.
5	Add accents without changing attack times.
6	Record; compare whether the pulse changed when the feel changed.

Exercise: cycle quarter notes -> eighth notes -> sixteenths -> offbeat eighths -> 3+3+2 while keeping the same metronome tempo.

Module B - Note-Length Ladder

Play G-C-D-G with four quarter-note attacks per measure. Only duration changes.

Level	Duration target	Left-hand behavior
1	100%	hold until next attack
2	75%	release late in beat
3	50%	release at midpoint
4	25%	short stab
5	percussive	pitch followed immediately by mute
6	mixed	long beat 1; short beats 2-4

Repeat with triads, shells, and full chords. The shorter versions must not speed up.

Module C - Muting and Ghost Contacts

Pattern	Grid	Goal
1	P-x- P-x- P-x- P-x-	clean release
2	P-xx P-xx P-xx P-xx	two ghosts after chord
3	PxPx PxPx PxPx PxPx	alternating pitch/ghost
4	Pxxx Pxxx Pxxx Pxxx	one pitch + three ghosts
5	--Px --Px --Px --Px	late-sixteenth chord
6	x-Px x-Px x-Px x-Px	ghost prepares pitched offbeat

Use three-string triads first, then four-string shells. A ghost contact may click but may not reveal a recognizable chord pitch.

Module D - Locking to Kick and Snare

Use a simple imagined drum grid: kick on 1 and 3, snare on 2 and 4. Then vary guitar placement around it.

Study	Guitar job	Count
Kick lock	short chord with kick	1, 3
Snare lock	chop with snare	2, 4
Kick answer	chord on & after kick	&1, &3
Snare pickup	a before 2 and 4	a1, a3
Split role	bass note with kick; chord with snare	1/3 bass, 2/4 chord
Backbeat ghosts	ghost on snare, pitch on following &	2-&2, 4-&4

The drum part is first spoken aloud: K S K S. Later use a metronome only on 2 and 4.

Module E - Bass/Guitar Interlock

Bass figure	Guitar response	Rule
Root on 1 and 3	upper triad on 2 and 4	do not duplicate bass register
Root-5th eighths	short shell on offbeats	leave bass attacks clear
Walking quarters	one chord stab per bar	guitar supplies space
Syncopated bass	sustained upper voicing	avoid rhythmic competition
Pedal bass	moving triad inversions	harmony moves above fixed low note
Bass fill on beat 4	guitar rests beat 4	do not cover the fill

Play the bass line yourself first. Then record it or loop it and add the guitar response.

Module F - Ahead, On, and Behind the Beat

This is microtiming, not a new subdivision. Start with a backing pulse or metronome. Do not attempt large deliberate delays.

Placement	Practice cue	Failure sign
On	attack centered with click	flam disappears into click
Slightly ahead	imagine pulling the band forward	tempo accelerates
Slightly behind	let click speak first; attack immediately after	attack becomes a late subdivision
Return on	remove offset without changing tempo	pulse shifts

Use one-note muted attacks before chords. Record and listen back; feel is judged by consistency, not by an exact millisecond target.

Module G - Eight Groove Cells, Same Harmonic Skills

Groove	Progression	Primary feel variable
Straight rock	G-D-Em-C	eighth-note down/up; long beat 1, shorter backbeats
Shuffle	A7-D7-E7-A7	triplet subdivision; middle triplet omitted
Funk	Am7-D9	sixteenth ghost grid; clipped pitched stabs
Reggae/Ska	C-F-G-C	short offbeat chords; silence on downbeats
Soul/R&B	Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7	upper shells; relaxed backbeat
Disco	Am7-D7-Gmaj7-Cmaj7	steady sixteenths; bright upper voicings
Country two-step	G-C-D-G	bass/chord alternation
Jam-band pocket	A-D-A-E	open space; chord hits plus melodic answer

These are foundational feel studies, not claims that each genre can be reduced to one pattern. Later Section XII levels expand the styles in depth.

Module H - Study 1 - Rock pocket

| G | D | Em | C | G | D | C | D |

Strong quarter pulse; controlled eighth-note sustain; backbeat release.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap only
2	muted strings
3	roots + shells
4	full groove
5	record with metronome on 2 and 4
6	remove click for 8 bars, then re-enter

Module H - Study 2 - Funk pocket

| Am7 | Am7 | D9 | D9 | Am7 | E7#9 | D9 | Am7 |

Sixteenth ghosts; pitched stabs remain short and dynamically above ghosts.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap only
2	muted strings
3	roots + shells
4	full groove
5	record with metronome on 2 and 4
6	remove click for 8 bars, then re-enter

Module H - Study 3 - Offbeat pocket

| C | F | G | C | Am | F | G | G |

Downbeats mostly silent; short offbeat upper-register chords.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap only
2	muted strings
3	roots + shells
4	full groove
5	record with metronome on 2 and 4
6	remove click for 8 bars, then re-enter

Module H - Study 4 - Soul pocket

| Cmaj7 | Am7 | Dm7 | G7 | Em7 | A7 | Dm7 | G7 |

Shells on backbeats; fills only after chord duration is controlled.

Pass	Requirement
1	clap/tap only
2	muted strings
3	roots + shells
4	full groove
5	record with metronome on 2 and 4
6	remove click for 8 bars, then re-enter

Module I - Thirty-Two-Bar Groove Capstone

Change feel without changing the underlying tempo. Announce the next groove during beat 4 of the previous section.

Bars	Harmony	Groove	Dynamic	Register
1-4	G-D-Em-C	straight rock	mf	middle
5-8	Am7-D9-Am7-E7#9	funk	mp	upper
9-12	C-F-G-C	offbeat	mp	upper
13-16	Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7	soul/R&B	mf	middle
17-20	A7-D7-E7-A7	shuffle	f	middle
21-24	Am7-D7-Gmaj7-Cmaj7	disco	f	upper
25-28	G-C-D-G	country two-step	mf	low+upper
29-32	A-D-A-E	jam-band pocket	mp -> f -> p	wide

Pass 1: muted strings. Pass 2: harmony. Pass 3: add bass/drum interlock. Pass 4: preserve note lengths. Pass 5: record one uninterrupted 32-bar performance.

Module J - Pocket Audit and Recovery

Failure	Repair
Groove speeds up	quarter-note foot + muted contacts only
Notes ring too long	practice release without changing attack
Ghosts contain pitch	reduce fretting pressure; narrow attack zone
Backbeat feels weak	remove fills; accent 2 and 4
Bass/guitar collide	delete guitar attack at bass landmark
Behind-beat becomes late	return on-beat, then use smaller offset
Style change loses tempo	one bar muted grid before adding chord texture
Form lost	roots only; rejoin at next 4-bar boundary

Mastery: score 14/16 or better on two separate days across pulse, note length, muting, drum lock, bass interlock, microtiming consistency, groove contrast, and recovery. No zero in pulse, note length, muting, or recovery.

Roadmap: Levels 85-90 complete Section XII Groove & Stylistic Rhythm. Levels 91-94 Advanced Expression, 95-99 Repertoire Integration, 100-104 Composition, Level 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after 105.